



RESEARCH REPORT · MAY 2026

2026 AI Recommendation Readiness Report

By Daniel Pokorny · Founder, Atom Foundry

We analyzed 500 Shopify and DTC ecommerce stores to understand how AI shopping agents — ChatGPT, Alexa for Shopping, Google AI Mode, and Perplexity — interpret, trust, and recommend ecommerce stores. The results reveal a critical readiness gap across the industry.

Only 4 stores out of 500 scored above 70. Zero stores reached the "Highly Recommendable" threshold. AI agents are systematically skipping most ecommerce stores.

500
Stores analyzed

45/100
Avg AI score

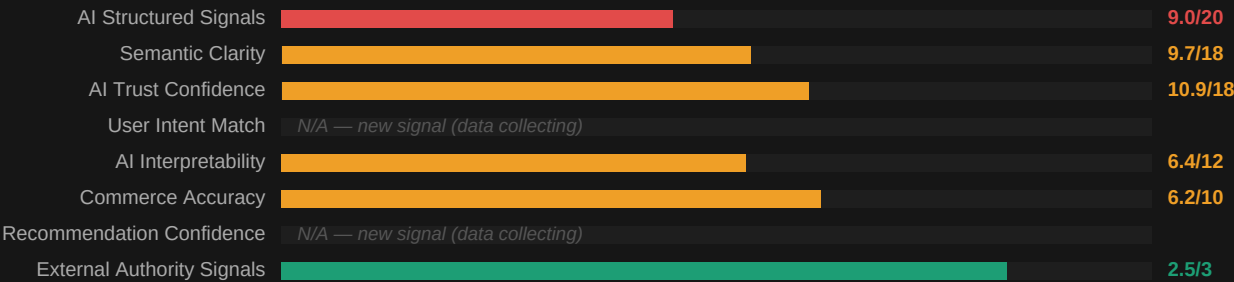
52%
AI Invisible Risk

0%
Highly Recommendable

8-FACTOR SCORING

Average Scores Across 8 AI Recommendation Factors

Based on real data from 500 scanned stores. Red = Critical Gap (<50%), Orange = Moderate (50–70%), Green = Good (70%+). Two signals marked N/A are newly added — data is still being collected.



READINESS CLASSIFICATION

AI Recommendation Readiness Matrix

Level	Score	What AI sees	Impact	Stores
Highly Recommendable	85–100	Full schema, clear content, strong trust signals	AI recommends confidently	0%
Partially Visible	50–84	Partial signals, AI guesses from text	Low confidence recommendation	48%
AI Invisible Risk	0–49	Missing schema, unclear content, no trust data	AI skips the store	52%

CASE STUDIES

Failure vs. Success: What AI Actually Sees

AI INVISIBLE — SCORE: 4/100 Major footwear retailer — anonymized What AI sees: "Store with products. No pricing. No schema. Cannot determine categories or trust level. Skipping." Why AI failed: Schema: 0/20 Trust: 0/18 Missing: JSON-LD, pricing markup, reviews, return policy — all invisible to AI crawlers.	AI READY — SCORE: 78/100 zappos.com What AI sees: "Footwear retailer with verified schema, structured product data, clear pricing, return policy, reviews. High recommendation confidence." Why AI succeeds: Schema: 20/20 Trust: 18/18 Has: JSON-LD Product schema, pricing, visible reviews, clear return and shipping policies.
--	---

NICHE SPOTLIGHT

Fashion & Footwear — 54 Stores Analyzed

Fashion is the largest analyzed category. Despite high brand recognition, most fashion stores score poorly — primarily missing schema markup and weak machine-readable trust signals.

Metric	Value	vs. All Stores
Stores analyzed	54	—
Average AI score	47/100	+2 vs avg
AI Invisible Risk (<50)	56%	+4%
AI Ready (70+)	4%	—
Top performer	setactiveclothing.com — 71/100	—
Worst performers	Multiple stores at 17/100	—
Most common gap	Schema markup avg 8.8/20	Critical

Infrastructure Is Not Enough

In May 2026, Shopify launched the Agentic Dashboard — generating llms.txt, llms-full.txt, and agents.md for every store. But having a file AI can read is not the same as having a store AI will recommend.

File	Purpose	Store Readiness Impact
llms.txt	Store description + agent endpoints	Auto-generated — content quality varies
llms-full.txt	Full JSON product catalog	Only as good as underlying product data
agents.md	Checkout instructions for AI agents	Enables autonomous purchases

KEY TAKEAWAYS

What This Means for Shopify Founders

- 01 Schema markup is the #1 gap**
Average score 9.0/20. Most stores have no structured data AI can reliably parse — making product extraction, pricing, and availability invisible to AI agents.
- 02 More than half of stores are AI invisible**
52% of 500 stores scored below 50. When buyers ask AI shopping assistants for recommendations, these stores are systematically excluded from the answer.
- 03 Even large brands fail**
Major retailers scored as low as 4/100. Brand recognition and traffic volume do not translate to AI recommendation readiness.
- 04 Shopify Agentic Dashboard changes the game — but not enough**
Every store now has llms.txt infrastructure. But content quality determines whether AI recommends you — not just file existence.
- 05 The race has already started**
AI-powered shopping is growing 400%+ year over year. Stores that optimize now will be embedded in AI answers. Stores that wait will find competitors already there.

METHODOLOGY

Atom Foundry crawled homepages of 500 Shopify and DTC stores between April–May 2026. Each store was evaluated across 8 AI recommendation factors using a proprietary scoring model analyzing 40+ signals including schema markup, semantic clarity, trust signals, pricing visibility, and content quality. AI interpretation assessed using GPT-4o trained to evaluate stores from the perspective of AI shopping agents.

Check your store's AI Recommendation Score — free

atomfoundry.dev